officials refused attempts to interfere with their rights of access. After failing to cross Checkpoint Charlie (and already late for the performance), the Lightners returned, accompanied by armed guards and four M-48 Patton tanks. This time, the *Volkspolizei* let them through (though by now the night at the opera had been ruined).

East German attempts to inspect US passports were neither initiated nor authorised by the Soviet authorities. Their reaction to the deployment of the US armoured vehicles, however, reflected concern that this was an act of Western provocation that could presage an assault on the wall. The Kennedy administration had no such intention. However, unbeknownst to Washington, General Clay, had – on his own initiative – ordered US combat engineers to construct a replica section of the wall in a secluded forest where they could practice assault techniques. This involved tanks with bulldozers of a kind that were later deployed at Checkpoint Charlie. When the US European commander-in chief, General Bruce Clarke, learned of Clay's actions, he angrily ordered an immediate halt to the enterprise (though the incident was not reported back to Washington).[37] The GRU, however, learned of what had happened in the forest.

History does not record the plays and operas the Lightners subsequently attended in East Berlin. However, over the ensuing week, US civilian officials continued to be challenged by the *Volkspolizei* and continued to cross the border with military escorts. Despite instructions from President Kennedy not to escalate the crisis, General Clay continued to probe. On 25 October 1961 he moved ten M-48 tanks close to the Friedrichstrasse crossing. Soviet tanks had not been seen in Berlin since the 1953 uprising, but a decision was taken to deploy thirty-three battle tanks (the number of US tanks in the city). When, on 27 October, ten M-48s were moved forward to Checkpoint Charlie, the Soviets responded in kind with ten of their T-55s. The tanks remained in a sixteen-hour stand-off from the afternoon of 27 October 1961 until the morning of 28 October 1961.

How dangerous was this moment? What might have happened if a belligerent or trigger-happy tank commander had opened fire? How far were political leaders in control of, or even aware of key developments? The same questions were to be asked of events in October 1962. Some of